

June 5, 2026

Michael Swanston, Principal
Woodland Hills Academy MS Magnet (LAUSD)
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Dear Principal Swanston,

I am applying for the math, science, and elective teaching position at Woodland Hills Academy MS Magnet for the 2026-2027 school year.

As the owner and sensei of my karate dojo, I strive to build a cross-disciplinary approach weaving academic concept into applied movement. Consider a simple defensive kick in response to an approaching punch: the reach-height tradeoff as a fraction of leg length comes from trigonometry, the counter balancing of head in opposite direction of the leg involves classic Newtonian mechanics, and the impossibility of kicking in time by watching the oncoming fist alone vs reading supporting body language comes from the brain's processing time of depth perception of the fist vs lateral movement of the shoulder and elbow.

In terms of class dynamics, the central challenge of leading a karate class is to foster an environment that balances the needs for structured, instructor-led learning at certain occasions (eg choreographed kata) with improvisatory, peer-to-peer exploration at others (eg free sparring). Too much discipline inhibits the latter while too much fun compromises the former. I've found the most effective common denominator is to link student motivation to their peer's growth: disrupting a lecture is disrespectful to their classmates who are trying to listen in order to learn, while a willingness to innovate and experiment pushes their partner to adapt to novel challenges.

I am excited for the opportunity to further discuss how I can adapt my experience and skills to meet the demands of the math classroom in order to best serve the needs of the students and the broader community.

Sincerely,

David Chung
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